

Month 1

The Beginning



● Your baby

Conception happens around week 2, and about a week later the tiny ball of cells settles into the lining of your womb. The cells that will become the placenta begin reaching toward your blood supply.

● You

You may not know yet. Hormones shift at implantation, and a missed period around week 4 is often the first sign. Some notice fatigue, tender breasts, or light spotting.

● Good to know

HER WORLD	In the pre- and perinatal view, her experience begins at conception, often before anyone knows she is there.
IMPRINTS	The circumstances of conception, and whether she was hoped for.
IF IT FEELS HARD	If you have known loss or a long road to conceive, hope and fear can arrive together. Both are welcome.

Month 2

The Discovery



● Your baby

Her heart begins to beat around week 6. The start of her brain and spinal cord closes, arm and leg buds appear, and by week 8 every major organ has begun. The first touch receptors form around her mouth.

● You

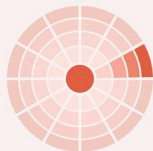
Nausea, deep fatigue, and a sharper sense of smell often peak now. For many this is the month of discovery, and joy, shock, fear, and ambivalence can arrive together.

● Good to know

HER WORLD	She senses your emotions through your body's chemistry. Everyday stress is buffered, and each return to calm helps.
IMPRINTS	How the news was first received. Conflict at home can reach her too.
IF IT FEELS HARD	Waiting for first scans is full of uncertainty. Hard feelings are natural and need no guilt.

Month 3

Taking Root



● Your baby

Now a fetus, she moves, stretches, hiccups, and swallows long before you can feel it. Sensitivity to touch spreads across her body, and some of your chemistry, including stress hormones, reaches her through the placenta.

● You

Nausea often eases near the end of this month as the placenta takes over hormone production. First prenatal visits and screenings usually happen now, and many families begin sharing the news.

● Good to know

HER WORLD	Nourishment, rest, and calm shape her lifelong health. Small, steady steps count.
IMPRINTS	Your own unresolved history may surface now. It deserves to be seen, gently.
YOUR CARE	Choose a model of care that fits you, and begin looking for a doula now, since many book early.

Month 4

The First Flutters



● Your baby

Her movements grow smoother and more coordinated, and she makes facial expressions. Her inner ear and taste buds are taking shape. Soon her movements will meet your hand.

● You

Energy often returns, and your belly begins to show. Some mothers, especially those who have been pregnant before, feel the first flutters. Your sense of yourself begins to shift toward motherhood.

● Good to know

HER WORLD	Her movements are her way of telling her story. Noticing them is your first conversation.
IMPRINTS	Whether her movements are noticed and met.
STORIES YOU HEAR	Others may share fearful birth stories. You can choose what you take in.

Practices · The Discovery

MONTH 2

● Tell her what is going on

1. When you feel a strong emotion, pause and take a slow breath.
2. Place a hand on your belly.
3. Name it simply: "I am tired and worried today."
4. Add: "This is about me, not you. You are welcome here."
5. This helps her know your feelings are yours, not hers to carry.

● Repair words for the news

1. If the news was hard to take in, find a quiet moment, alone or with your partner.
2. Speak to her: "When we found out, we were scared. That was about us, not you."
3. Finish with: "We are so glad you are here."

FOR YOUR OWN HEALING · WHAT SURFACES

1. Notice if pregnancy brings up memories or feelings from your own childhood.
2. Write them down without judging them.
3. Meet them gently, the way you would meet a friend.
4. Invite your partner to notice what is surfacing for them too.

If the feelings are big, reach out to a trauma-informed therapist. You do not have to hold them alone.

BABY'S QUESTION
Am I welcome?

Strange · Ham & Klimo · Raffai · Davis-Floyd

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Practices · The Beginning

MONTH 1

● Grounding

1. Sit or stand, and feel your feet on the floor or your weight in the chair.
2. Notice the place where your body is most supported.
3. Breathe in slowly, and let the out-breath be a little longer.
4. Stay for three breaths. As you slow down, so does her world.
5. Return to this whenever you feel rushed or unsettled.

● Oxytocin moments

1. A few times a day, do something you enjoy on purpose: a warm drink, sunlight, a hug, music.
2. Let yourself feel the pleasure for a full minute.
3. After a stressful moment, this helps wire her to move from stress back to calm.

FOR YOUR OWN HEALING · YOUR OWN BEGINNING

1. Reflect on what you know about how you came to be.
2. If you can, ask your mother or family how the news of you was received.
3. Write down what you learn, and what you feel as you hear it.
4. Invite your partner to explore their own beginning too.

Meet whatever you find with kindness, for yourself and for those who came before you.

BABY'S QUESTION
Am I wanted?

Strange · Chamberlain · Davis-Floyd

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Practices · The First Flutters

MONTH 4

● Hands on the belly

1. Lie or sit comfortably, and rest both hands on your belly.
2. Breathe slowly and wait. There is no rush.
3. When you feel a flutter, say what you notice: "I feel you there."
4. Ask her simply, "How are you today?" and notice how she moves in answer.
5. Keep a small note of when she moves most. It becomes your shared rhythm.

● Choose your stories

1. When someone begins a frightening birth story, you can say, "I would love to hear it after my baby is born."
2. Seek out two or three stories of births that went well.
3. If a story leaves you shaken, talk it through with someone you trust.

FOR YOUR OWN HEALING · YOUR TIME IN THE WOMB

1. Ask your mother what her pregnancy with you was like: calm, stressful, a time of loss or conflict.
2. Listen with compassion for her, too.
3. Notice how her story might live in you today.
4. Invite your partner to ask their mother the same.

If your mother is not available, you can simply reflect and write what you imagine or sense.

BABY'S QUESTION
When I reach out, will someone meet me?

Strange · Raffai · Emerson

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Practices · Taking Root

MONTH 3

● A daily welcome

1. Find a quiet moment each day this month.
2. Place a hand low on your belly, and take a slow breath.
3. Say hello: "Hello, little one. I know you are here."
4. Tell her one small thing about your day.
5. It is fine to begin before you feel ready. The welcome grows as you practice it.

● One steady step

1. Choose one small change: a nourishing snack, an earlier night, a short walk.
2. Tell her about it: "This is for both of us."
3. After a week, notice how you feel, and choose the next step.

FOR YOUR OWN HEALING · YOUR STORY, GENTLY SHARED

1. If something from your past is surfacing, you do not have to carry it alone.
2. Share only what you choose, with someone safe: a partner, friend, or care provider.
3. Notice how it feels to be heard.
4. Remind yourself that healing now is a gift to you and to her.

If it feels too big, ask your care provider for a referral to a therapist.

BABY'S QUESTION
Is it safe to be here?

Strange · Nathanielsz · Seng & Taylor

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Month 5

The First Sounds



● Your baby

Hearing begins around weeks 18 to 20. Voices, music, laughter, and raised voices now reach her as vibration through the womb wall.

● You

You will likely feel her move now. Your ligaments soften, and the anatomy scan usually happens around week 20. Feeling her move can turn an idea into a relationship.

● Good to know

HER WORLD Your voice, carried through your own body, is the loudest and clearest sound she hears.

IMPRINTS The sound world of your home may stay with her. After a loud or tense moment, tell her what happened.

IF NEWS IS HARD If the scan brings unexpected news, you can take time before deciding. Fear or grief is natural.

Month 6

The Rhythm



● Your baby

She begins to respond to sound, often startling at a sudden noise. Her lungs begin making surfactant and her brain grows quickly. She moves through loose cycles of rest and activity, at a rhythm much slower than yours.

● You

Your belly grows quickly, and back aches, heartburn, or swelling may begin. A glucose screening is usually offered between weeks 24 and 28. Your thoughts may begin turning toward the birth.

● Good to know

HER WORLD The pace of your days and your moments of settling may be how she learns rhythm.

IMPRINTS Everyone brings a birth story into the birth room. Yours, and your mother's, may come to mind now.

IF NEWS IS HARD A diagnosis such as gestational diabetes is information to guide your care, not a judgment on your body.

Month 7

Light and Voices



● Your baby

Her eyes open and can sense light through your belly. She gains fat, practices breathing, and spends much of each day in REM sleep, the stage linked with dreaming. The voices she hears most will be familiar after birth.

● You

The third trimester begins. Sleep grows harder, breath shorter, and practice contractions more noticeable. Anticipation grows, and so can fear of birth.

● Good to know

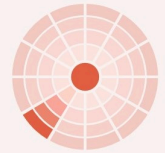
YOUR HORMONES The hormones of birth flow best when you feel safe, private, and unobserved.

IMPRINTS Fear in the room: yours, your family's, or a provider's past cases.

PLANS CAN CHANGE Exploring other paths, such as a longer labor or a cesarean, lets you meet a change as a choice.

Month 8

The Turning



● Your baby

She gains weight quickly and space grows tight. Studies first show her responding to your voice differently from other voices. Antibodies cross the placenta, and many babies settle head down now.

● You

Your uterus presses up under your ribs and builds oxytocin receptors for labor. Your breasts may begin leaking colostrum. Nesting energy often arrives.

● Good to know

POSITION If she is still breech near 36 weeks, options include waiting, gentle positioning, a version, or a breech birth with a skilled provider.

IMPRINTS Space and holding as room grows tight, and how decisions about her are made.

YOUR CHOICES You can ask about benefits, risks, and alternatives, take a moment, and say yes or no.

Practices · The Rhythm

MONTH 6

● Three daily oxytocin breaks

1. Pick three daily cues, such as waking, lunch, and bedtime.
2. At each, take one minute for something pleasant: a stretch, a song, a warm hand on your belly.
3. Breathe slowly and let yourself enjoy it.
4. Practiced now, this groove of calm is easier to find in labor and after birth.

● Gather your support

1. Choose a childbirth class that fits you, and check in on your doula.
2. Name the rest you need, and ask family or work for it in plain words.
3. Choose one person you can call on a hard day.

FOR YOUR OWN HEALING · YOUR BELIEFS ABOUT BIRTH

1. Write three words that come to mind when you think of birth.
2. For each, ask where it came from: your own birth, your mother, films, or friends.
3. Keep the words that strengthen you, and let the others soften.
4. Invite your partner to do the same, and share your words.

A belief you can name is a belief you can choose to change.

BABY'S QUESTION Can I rest here?

Strange · Emerson · Raffai

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Practices · The First Sounds

MONTH 5

● The kick game

1. Choose a time she is often active, such as after a meal or when you lie down to rest.
2. Rest your hand where you feel her move, and take a slow breath.
3. When she kicks, press gently back once in the same spot and say, "Hello, I feel you."
4. Wait and notice. If she answers, press again. If not, simply rest your hand there.
5. Invite your partner to try it, speaking close to your belly.

● A song for her

1. Choose one song, rhyme, or short phrase that feels like yours.
2. Sing or say it to her once a day, at about the same time if you can.
3. After she is born, use the same one when she needs comfort. She may know it.

FOR YOUR OWN HEALING · YOUR BIRTH STORY

1. Ask your mother or family how you were born: how long the labor was, who was there, and whether you were kept close.
2. Write down what you learn, and what you feel as you hear it.
3. Notice anything that echoes your hopes or fears for this birth.
4. Share it with your partner, and invite them to explore theirs.

If it stirs strong feelings, go gently, and reach out to someone you trust or a therapist.

BABY'S QUESTION Is my world a kind place?

Strange · Ham & Klimo (2000) · Emerson

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Practices · The Turning

MONTH 8

● Tell her what you would like

1. Sit or lie comfortably, and rest your hands on your belly.
2. Breathe until you feel settled.
3. Speak to her: "When you are ready, you can turn head down. That will make the way out easier."
4. Thank her, whatever she does.
5. Repeat a few times a week, gently, without pressure.

● Practice your questions

1. For any choice, ask: What are the benefits? The risks? The alternatives? What if we wait?
2. Try it on a small choice at your next visit.
3. Remember you can always say, "I need a moment to think."

FOR YOUR OWN HEALING · WITH YOUR PARTNER

1. Partners carry fears and birth stories too.
2. Invite your partner to share how they imagine the birth, and what worries them.
3. Listen without fixing.
4. Agree on one way they can support you when it matters most.

A partner who feels heard can hold the space more steadily for you both.

BABY'S QUESTION Will I be held as space grows tight?

Strange · Fischbein & Freeze · MFCI · Emerson

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Practices · Light and Voices

MONTH 7

● Pacing

1. Each day, choose one moment to slow everything down: walk, speak, and move at half speed.
2. Add small pauses between tasks: one breath, a hand on your belly.
3. Notice how she moves when you slow down.
4. Her rhythm is slower than yours. Slowing down helps her stay with you.

● Imagine your birth space

1. Picture where you will give birth. What helps you feel safe there?
2. List what you want: dim light, music, who is there, freedom to move.
3. Choose who will speak up for you, such as your partner or a doula, and share the list.

FOR YOUR OWN HEALING · FEARS AND THEIR ROOTS

1. Write down your fears about this birth.
2. Beside each, ask: does it echo my own birth, my mother's, or a story I heard?
3. Naming where a fear comes from can soften its hold.
4. Invite your partner to speak their fears too, so they do not fill the birth room unspoken.

Feeling fear is natural. Talking it through is how it loosens.

BABY'S QUESTION Can I trust those around me?

Strange · Buckley · Emerson · MFCI

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Month 9

Ripening



Your baby

Her lungs finish maturing, and full term arrives at 39 to 40 weeks. Research suggests her own lungs release a signal that helps start labor, so she may have a part in deciding when birth begins.

You

She may drop lower, easing your breath but adding pressure. Practice contractions grow stronger and your cervix begins to soften. You may feel ready, impatient, or afraid, sometimes all in one day.

Good to know

TIMING	Labor usually begins when you are both ready. Induction is a choice to weigh, not an automatic step.
IMPRINTS	Being waited for, or hurried: whether her readiness is trusted.
SUPPORT	Plan who will stay with you through anything unexpected.

Labor

The Threshold



Your baby

Each contraction presses and releases her whole body like a long embrace. Her own stress hormones surge to protect her and prepare her lungs. She may sense pressure, rhythm, and pause.

You

Oxytocin brings the waves, and endorphins ease pain and carry you inward. You labor best when you feel private, safe, and unobserved, free to move, eat, and drink.

Good to know

THE SPACE	When labor feels watched or unsafe, adrenaline rises and can slow it. Dim light, quiet, and trusted people keep it flowing.
IMPRINTS	The journey through, supported or interrupted. Ask the reason for any procedure.
IF PLANS CHANGE	Pain is part of labor; suffering is not, and choosing relief needs no guilt. Ask for someone by your side, clear explanations, and time to respond.

Birth

Through the Gate



Your baby

In the final push, a surge of noradrenaline makes her alert, often with wide open eyes at your first meeting. She takes her first breath, and her circulation changes course within minutes. Light, air, sound, and gravity arrive all at once.

You

A surge of adrenaline gives you strength for the final pushes, and many mothers feel a burst of energy to meet the baby. Pain medication can soften this surge, so you may both be less alert at first.

Good to know

HER FIRST SENSES	Harsh lights, noise, and routine suctioning can overwhelm her. You can ask for dim light and calm.
GENTLE CARE	You can ask for delayed cord clamping, and for a gentle cesarean if surgery is needed.
IF IT CHANGES COURSE	A cesarean or separation is not a failure. She can be told what is happening and held close as soon as possible.

First Hour

The Welcome



Your baby

Placed skin to skin, she warms, steadies her heart and breathing, and may crawl toward the breast on her own. She knows your smell, your heartbeat, and your voice, now from the outside.

You

Skin to skin, oxytocin and prolactin peak. Oxytocin helps the placenta release and protects against bleeding, and prolactin begins milk and mothering. Awe, relief, and exhaustion may arrive together.

Good to know

THE GOLDEN HOUR	You can ask for newborn checks to happen on your chest, and for the first bath to wait.
IMPRINTS	Welcome or separation. Staying together is part of gentle, humanistic care.
IF YOU WERE APART	The bond is not lost. Skin to skin and closeness can begin as soon as you are together.

Practices · The Threshold

LABOR

● Tell her what is happening

1. As a wave begins, rest a hand on your belly if you can.
2. Say, out loud or inside, "Here comes another wave. We are doing this together."
3. When it passes: "That one is over. You are doing well."
4. Before anything changes, such as moving, a monitor, or a transfer, tell her first.
5. When you cannot speak, your partner or doula can speak to her for you.

● Ground between waves

1. Feel your feet, or the places your body is held: the bed, the ball, the water.
2. Breathe out a little longer than you breathe in. Let your jaw and shoulders soften.
3. Rest in the pause. She feels you settle, and the next wave can find you calmer.

FOR YOUR OWN HEALING · BEFORE LABOR

1. If you have given birth before, tell that story to someone who listens without judgment.
2. Notice which moments still feel heavy, and name what you would want to feel different this time.
3. Share those wishes with your partner and birth team, so they can help protect them.

If an earlier birth was hard, support from a trauma-informed therapist can help before this one begins.

BABY'S QUESTION Can I make it through?

Strange · Buckley (2003) · Emerson · Seng & Taylor

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Practices · Ripening

MONTH 9

● Tell her about the birth to come

1. Choose a calm moment each day, and rest a hand on your belly.
2. Tell her what will happen: "Soon you will be born. It will be big, and I will be with you."
3. Tell her who will be there to meet her.
4. Rehearse the first words you want her to hear: "You made it. I am so happy you are here."

● Gathering colostrum

1. First ask your provider if it is right for you. It is usually begun after 37 weeks.
2. Once a day, with clean hands, gently massage, then press behind the areola.
3. Collect any drops in a small syringe and store them as your provider advises.

FOR YOUR OWN HEALING · WAITING WITH KINDNESS

1. When pressure to have the baby already builds, notice how it feels in your body.
2. Write: "What do I need while I wait?"
3. Ask for it, from your partner, family, or care team.
4. Remind yourself and her: "We will meet when we are both ready."

Impatience, fear, and readiness can all arrive in one day. None of them needs guilt.

BABY'S QUESTION Will I be given time?

Strange · Singh et al. · Buckley

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Practices · The Welcome

FIRST HOUR

● Skin to skin

1. Ask that she be placed on your bare chest, with a warm blanket over you both.
2. Let her rest, breathe, and find her way.
3. Watch her cues: rooting, licking, moving toward the breast.
4. Keep the first hour quiet and unhurried. Visitors can wait.

● Tell her the story of her birth

1. In the days after, hold her close and tell her the story of her birth, slowly.
2. Name what happened, and how it felt.
3. If anything was hard: "I am sorry that happened. It was not your fault. You are safe now."
4. End with: "I love you."

FOR YOUR OWN HEALING · TELLING YOUR BIRTH STORY

1. In the weeks after, tell the story of this birth to someone who listens without judgment.
2. Invite your partner to tell theirs too.
3. Offer the same kindness to the younger self in your own birth story.
4. Watch for lingering distress, such as flashbacks, numbness, or avoidance.

If distress stays, reach out to perinatal mental health support. You can heal alongside your baby.

BABY'S QUESTION Do I belong here, with you?

Strange · Davis-Floyd · MFCI · Seng & Taylor

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Practices · Through the Gate

BIRTH

● Narrate her arrival

1. As she arrives, slow everything down.
2. Say to her: "You are out now. You made it. You can take a breath."
3. Pause, and let her look at you.
4. Then: "I am so happy you are here. I love you."
5. If you cannot speak, your partner can say it for you.

● Repair after intensity

1. If the birth was intense or plans changed, ground yourself: feel your body, take a breath.
2. Tell her: "That was a lot. It is over. You are safe now. It was not your fault."
3. Repairs build stronger trust than if the hard moment had never happened.

FOR YOUR OWN HEALING · KINDNESS FOR YOURSELF

1. Remind yourself that you made the best choices you could with what you knew in the moment.
2. Offer yourself the words you offered her: "That was a lot. You are safe now."
3. Let someone care for you, too.

A birth that changed course is not a failure. You can meet yourself with the same kindness you offer her.

BABY'S QUESTION Is it safe to arrive?

Strange · Verny · Buckley · Davis-Floyd

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